



A Case for the Learner's Perspective

Now, while the conversation about the need and means of upskilling goes on, the ground reality is a little different. A predicament skilling centres often find themselves in is having to deal with students who have no desire to upskill. This is at the expense of large sums of time and money spent by the industry on upskilling, and students spending time learning something they do not wish to. A complete lose-lose situation. What can be done?

For starters, putting up more rigid screening tests for potential students is a good way to weed out unsuitable people. Second, Dr Kalsi suggests that keeping the sword of some monetary investment on the student's part can be a good way to make sure that only those who are truly interested are upskilled. It is also important to understand what the people are actually interested in—be it AI/ML, IoT, or Big Data Analytics. Mapping a person for the right skill and competency is very important.

highlighting the opportunities that are available to them to utilise these skills.

The recent policy of the government to introduce semiconductor design manufacturing and the subsequent India Semiconductor Mission have opened doors for the telecom sector to emerge as an economic leader. It is expected that soon every piece of metal will have silicon embedded in it because silicon is what provides a brain to the metal. But that brain will only be able to communicate through connectivity. Hence, telecom provides it with life.

In a similar vein, the recent production-linked incentive (PLI) schemes for electronics manufacturing present further opportunities for skilled manpower to put their talent to use. The introduction of 5G has opened incredible avenues for growth across sectors. And as technologies like IoT, Industry 4.0, and AI/ML keep propping up in conversations, the significance of connectivity and data becomes clearer. But so do the challenges that accompany them.

The country has an impressive herd of skilled manpower for 2G, 3G, and even 4G. However, 5G is a different ballgame. "The infrastructure which is required for 5G is different. It has more additions to it, and hence skilling needs to happen so that the workforce understands what each of these additions has to offer," remarks T.R. Dua, Director General, DIPA.

Talent—the newest competitive edge

India's biggest demographic dividend and asset is the people. Every year, thousands in the workforce migrate to foreign countries in search of employment and better opportunities. Arvind Bali, CEO of TSSC, says, "The responsibility on our shoulders is tremendous as this provides the opportunity to be global skilling leaders."

This is no easy feat, though. The skilling mantra needs to work on a certain paradigm. The centres need to be omnichannel. People need to have the assurance that they will be continuously learning through digital channels and workplaces.

Skilling needs to be aspirational. Given the kind of enthusiasm and drive in the youth today, this is hardly a challenge. The real challenge lies in honing that drive and channelising it in the right direction.

As far as building international cadence goes, Bali provides an interesting insight: "It is no surprise that countries in the Middle East have numerous takers for Indian talent. But what about skilled talent? If we can send these people with a certain level of training, and make them more desirable in terms of skillset, the opportunities for these people increase manifold, and so does our quality of Indian talent across the globe."

But there is a need to recognise skilled manpower on the home turf

too. "We need a full spectrum of trained manpower in 5G. Right from the design to implementation and commissioning and finally to operation and maintenance. And then repair and maintenance services," says Dr Kalsi.

It is no surprise that most upskilling and reskilling today happens at the workplace. But as the demand for the technology grows, a stronger foundation needs to be set.

Adding courses on 5G development in the syllabus of engineering college students can help, but a more effective way could be to also provide them with an easy way to opt out by making these courses optional, so that only the ones interested are enrolled. A smaller group also provides space to improve the quality of the course through apprenticeship programmes and partnerships with the industry and fluid practical assignments.

Providing this early on can help make the youth job-ready by the time they come out of the college. Subsequently, creating modules of 60-190 minutes that form the base of the technology can be distributed across the school level to start the process sooner. These modules can also help reskill entry-level employees who have little to no idea about what 5G entails.

Training the trainers

A major roadblock in successfully upskilling the workforce is finding people who are adept enough to impart the necessary skill. Rehman Khan Suri, Professor at DSEU, notes, "The main challenge today is providing training to the faculty which can train the skill in the particular skill-set. With the pace at which technology is changing, academia cannot really match that pace without skilled academicians."

Good faculty development programmes, as such, are not an option anymore. They are necessary to make way for a larger skilled man-